



Slumthing SPECIAL

Seeking to earn brownie points with slum dwellers, the Maharashtra Government extends the cut-off date for the regularisation of slums which it had earlier rejected

| By Malini Bhupta |

Mumbai is a squatters' paradise. In the world's seventh most expensive city, buying a home remains a dream for most even if they earn seven-figure salaries. But those living in shanties since January 1, 2000 will now become the proud owners of a small studio apartment in the centre of the town without paying a penny. Far from being a symbol of India's economic growth, this financial capital is fast becoming a city of slums, where the middle-classes pay taxes and slum dwellers walk away with free homes.

In stark contrast to the 1970s, when slums were treated as illegal

settlements by state governments, 60 per cent of the city today resides in slums, making this populace a mouth-watering votebank for politicians. Allegedly, the Congress has worked very closely with numerous slum lords to cultivate this votebank.

Before every election, the Congress-Nationalist Congress Party combine promises extending the date of regularisation of slums. Making it an election issue, the Congress promised to extend the date of regularisation from January 1995 to January 2000. However, on coming to power, the party called it an error and failed to im-

plement its promise for five years. On the eve of Assembly elections, the Ashok Chavan government has decided to go against the High Court verdict and legalise all slums that have come up till January 2000. If approved by the Supreme Court, slums that have come up between 1995 and 2000 will be considered legal and become eligible for development, re-development and other schemes of the state government. Says Bharat Kumar Raut, Shiv Sena MP: "We have opposed this because deadlines have been extended in 1985 and 1995. There is no reason to do it again. This is purely a land grab

The **GOVERNMENT OBVIOUSLY IS HAPPY** to capture a votebank at the cost of its land.